

TODAY'S TEA LOVER

There is more high-quality loose-leaf tea available to us, and more infusion gadgets to prepare it, than ever before. This is creating a culture of tea followers with a thirst for knowledge and new tea experiences.

In the first half of the last century all of the tea that was consumed around the world was loose-leaf. As lifestyles changed, and convenience became more important than flavor and tradition, consumers were won over by the ease of preparing tea using a tea bag. Now, discerning tea drinkers are returning to loose-leaf tea, honing their tasting skills, and acquiring knowledge of a vast array of high-quality teas that they are able to prepare and drink in their homes as well as in restaurants and cafés.

Curious consumers might want to discover more about global tea cultures, such as ancient tea ceremonies, or go online to connect with tea growers and sellers, tea specialists, and tea bloggers to share and accumulate information from the world of tea.

TEA GOES MAINSTREAM

An indication that this passion for tea is no passing fad is the increasing variety and availability of excellent quality tea. Walk into any supermarket and you will find a diverse selection of loose-leaf tea, as well as the

convenient new take on the tea bag—the cleverly designed silk pyramid sachet filled with high-quality loose leaves, such as jasmine pearls, Chinese greens, and Silver Needle white tips. One doesn't have to travel very far in most cities to find a teashop that is well stocked with tea from the far corners of the globe. Cafés that previously served only coffee or generic black tea have cleared shelf space for specialty loose-leaf tea with the latest tea gadgets and knowledgeable staff to serve it. Improved tea lists are appearing on restaurant menus, and some “tea bars” are offering tea cocktails and tea cuisine. Unique and exotic teas are entering our everyday consciousness and all the signs tell us that this tea trend is continuing to grow.

With all this recent exposure to specialty and premium tea, a new breed of tea-lover is developing: a tea-lover that treks to countries of origin, studies tea customs, meets growers, and brings home rare Pu'er and little-known green teas to share with their tea-loving friends.



MIXOLOGY

More than just a mixer, the right tea can add layers of flavor and complexity to a cocktail.



JAPANESE GREEN

Green tea from Japan, such as this Sencha, is famous for its delicate sweetness and marine flavor.